

The Pill TURNS 50

The first birth-control pill introduced in May 1960 revolutionised women's lives. Yet myths and misconceptions govern how many women think about and use the pill. Here are some...

MYTH: THE PILL MAKES YOU GAIN WEIGHT

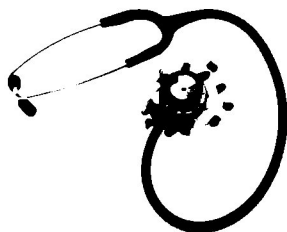


REALITY: Not really. The claim may have been valid for the early versions which contained high levels of estrogen—leading to water retention and increased appetite. Nowadays, most versions of the pill have only half the amount.

MYTH: YOU NEED A BREAK FROM THE PILL EVERY NOW AND THEN

REALITY: Not true. In fact, repeated restarting of the pill might be more harmful than the relatively steady-state situation that is maintained during sustained use, say experts.

MYTH: THE PILL CAUSES CANCER



REALITY: Pills may actually bring down the risk of ovarian and endometrial cancers (by up to 50 per cent if taken for a year). No links have been established with breast cancer too.

MYTH: THE MOST RISKY TIME TO MISS A PILL IS IN THE MIDDLE OF THE PACK



REALITY: It's the least risky time. Women need to take seven consecutive active pills to prevent ovulation. They can then miss seven days without risk, which is what occurs during the pill-free week. The most unsafe time is at the beginning or end of a pack because it extends the pill-free week past seven days.

MYTH: BIRTH-CONTROL PILLS CAUSE MENSTRUAL CYCLES TO CEASE



REALITY: The opposite is true. Many women are actually prescribed birth-control pills to help regulate their cycles. The pill may also help reduce menstrual cramps and lighten blood flow.

MYTH: LONG-TERM USE AFFECTS FERTILITY

REALITY: No connection. Fertility can return almost immediately after stopping the pill. The pill actually contributes to the preservation of women's fertility as it reduces a number of conditions which impact fertility (e.g. ectopic pregnancy, endometriosis, fibroids).



MYTH: ALL PILLS ARE THE SAME

REALITY: Combination pills contain two types of hormones, estrogen and progestin. Most pills contain the same estrogen—ethinyl estradiol—but many brands use different types of progestin. The progestin can cause unpleasant side-effects, such as breast swelling and tenderness, acne and fluid retention, in some. Consult your doctor for the pill best suited for you.

